

Squirrel-like rodents

PHYLUM	Chordata
CLASS	Mammalia
ORDER	Rodentia
SUBORDER	Sciuromorpha
FAMILIES	3
SPECIES	332

This group, which is defined by the arrangement of the jaw muscles (see p.116), embraces a variety of rodents, such as marmots and squirrels. Members of the squirrel family all have long whiskers, a cylindrical body, and a well-haired tail. Species from other families

vary anatomically from the ground-dwelling mountain beaver to the mouselike dormouse. Squirrel-like rodents are distributed worldwide, in a variety of habitats.

BALANCING ACT
The Eurasian red squirrel uses its tail for balance when running along branches.



Aplodontia rufa

Mountain beaver



Length 9–17 in (23–43 cm)
Tail ¾–2¼ in (2–5.5 cm)
Weight 1¼–3¼ lb (0.8–1.5 kg)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location S.W. Canada to S.W. USA



This rodent digs its tunnels and home (lodge) under felled trees, and so is increasing where commercial logging occurs. It lives alone and its tunnel

openings lead directly to food such as bark, twigs, shoots, and soft plants, which it brings back to eat or store. Also known as the sewellel, it climbs well and destroys many small trees. The long fur is black to red-brown above, yellow-brown beneath, with a white spot below each ear.



Marmota flaviventer

Yellow-bellied marmot

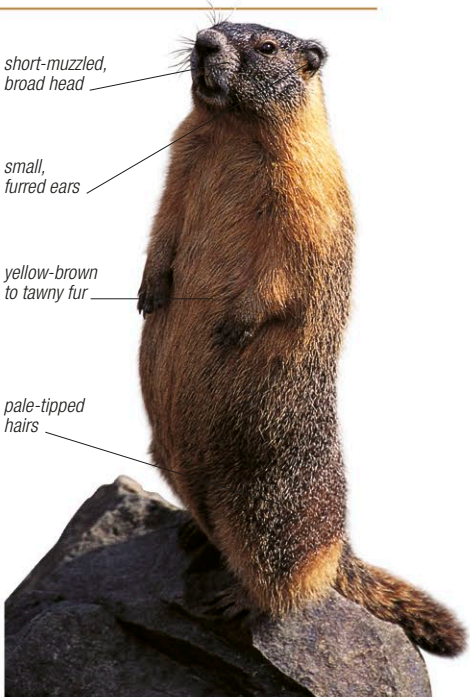


Length 18½–28 in (47–70 cm)
Tail 5–9 in (13–22 cm)
Weight 3¼–11 lb (1.5–5 kg)
Social unit Group
Status Least concern

Location S.W. Canada to W. USA



Adaptable in habitat, the yellow-bellied marmot takes a wide diet of grasses, flowers, herbs, and seeds. It feeds mainly in the morning and late afternoon, then grooms with others in its colony—usually one male and several females. Its long hibernation lasts up to 8 months. The 4–5 young are weaned after 20–30 days.



Marmota monax

Woodchuck



Length 16¾–26¾ in (41.5–66.5 cm)
Tail 4–6 in (10–15.5 cm)
Weight 7¾–8¾ lb (3.4–4.1 kg)
Social unit Variable
Status Least concern

Location Alaska and W. Canada to E. Canada and E. USA



Also called the groundhog, this is one of the largest, strongest ground squirrels. It feeds mainly in the afternoon, often in a loose group with others of its kind, on a variety of seeds, grasses, clovers, fruit, and small animals such as grasshoppers and snails. Despite its size, it is an able climber and swims well. In autumn, it excavates a deeper burrow for its long winter hibernation. During this period it survives on stored body fat, which

makes up about 20 percent of its body weight. In North America, February 2 is Groundhog Day, when the woodchuck supposedly peers from its winter burrow to assess the weather. The woodchuck regularly shows aggressive behavior to its own kind, especially as males fight for dominance in the spring mating season. It also vigorously defends its burrow by arching its back, jumping, flicking its stiffened tail, and chattering its bared teeth. When frightened, it makes a sharp whistling alarm call.



Tamias striatus

Eastern chipmunk



Length 5¾–6 in (14.5–15 cm)
Tail 3¼–3¾ in (8.7–9.3 cm)
Weight 3¾–3¾ oz (93–101 g)
Social unit Individual
Status Least concern

Location S.E. Canada to C. and E. USA



The eastern chipmunk, occasionally kept as a pet, is also familiar in the wild, as a bold visitor to picnic sites. It

frequents mainly deciduous woods, especially birch, as well as woody areas containing abundant rock crevices. It can climb but forages mainly on the ground for seeds and nuts, especially during mid-morning and midafternoon, carrying food items in its cheek pouches. The basic coloring of the eastern chipmunk is grayish or reddish brown, becoming paler red on the rump. It lives alone in its burrow system and hibernates during winter, although it may emerge on mild days to feed. The noisy “chip” and “cuk” calls act as alarm signals for fellow chipmunks and other small animals living nearby.

